ROMAN NAVAL WARFARE



Roman port
This detail from a Roman fresco of the 1st century CE shows the port at Castellammare di Stabia in the Gulf of Naples. During the first two centuries of the Empire ports like this ringed the entire Mediterranean, which the Romans justifiably called *Mare Nostrum* (Our Sea).

IN THE THIRD CENTURY BCE the Mediterranean was host to a diversity of naval powers large and small. The western part was dominated by Carthage, a North African city founded by the Phoenicians, which continued their great seafaring tradition in trade and war. In the eastern Mediterranean the wealthy Hellenic states of Antagonid Macedonia and Ptolemaic Egypt maintained imposing fleets of outsized warships appropriate to their notions of royal prestige and large-scale warfare. The island of Rhodes, a major maritime trading center, had an efficiently organized fleet of lighter ships, used to suppress piracy and deter the predatory ambitions of larger states. But all of these diverse maritime powers, along with Seleucid Syria, were ultimately subjected to the naval power of Rome, a state with no tradition of shipbuilding or seafaring that created a navy out of nothing in 260 BCE.

INSTANT NAVAL POWER

Rome's progress to naval dominance began with the defeat of the Carthaginians in the First Punic War (264–241 BCE), continued with the extension of Roman power to the eastern Mediterranean in the 2nd century BCE, and was completed in 67 BCE with the suppression of piracy by Pompey the Great. These successes were not achieved through radical naval innovations, although Roman technical ingenuity did play its part. Rome's first fleet—100 quinqueremes and 20 triremes built in 60 days—was created partly by copying a galley captured from the Carthaginian enemy.

The Roman quinqueremes were smaller than the huge ungainly warships of the Hellenic states, but they still probably had five men operating each oar and 28 oars to a side. This made them better suited to the largely inexperienced crews that Rome had available than the one-man-per-oar trireme. On these heavier and less maneuverable vessels, oarsmen needed muscle power rather than skill. Most important, the quinqueremes could carry some 120 soldiers, enabling the Romans to transfer their proven supremacy in land warfare to the sea. Although most of their ships were still fitted with rams, the Romans' prime aim in naval warfare was to board the enemy's galleys. They would first soften them up by bombarding them with missiles from wooden towers that stood at the prow and stern of their ships.

Sailing from Alexandria
A trireme carrying a large force of legionaries is rowed out of the port of Alexandria, one of the main centers of Roman naval power in the east. Many Egyptians served as oarsmen and sailors in the imperial Roman navy.

